Kō　候

The Year, in Seventy-Two

FOUR-SEASON ILLUSTRATED BOOK PILOT

24 OCTOBER 2026 / DESIGN PROOF



牡丹華

Peonies bloom

Botan hana saku

The air has grown thick with warmth and the sweet, almost intoxicating scent of peonies unfolding in temple gardens and private courtyards. Their petals — layered like silk robes, flushed from palest shell-pink to deepest crimson — seem too extravagant for the modest scale of a flower. This is spring's final flourish, a last gesture of abundance before the rains.

Peonies heavy with dew bow toward the earth each morning, their blooms so full they barely hold their form. Tree frogs have begun their evening chorus in earnest, and the first fireflies flicker in damp thickets near streams. Young bamboo shoots have pushed through the soil with startling speed, their pale green tips visible along forest edges.

The peony, known as the 'king of flowers,' has long symbolized nobility, prosperity, and feminine beauty in Japanese art. This period also marks the heart of Golden Week, when families travel to ancestral homes and temple grounds are crowded with visitors admiring the last of spring's showiest blooms. Children's Day on May 5th brings carp streamers rippling against bright skies.

牡丹散りて打ちかさなりぬ二三片

Peony petals fall — / two, three, overlapping / on the garden stone



蓮始開

Lotus blossoms open

Hasu hajimete hiraku

In the heavy stillness before sunrise, lotus buds that have waited all night begin to open with an almost audible sigh. The air above temple ponds grows thick with their honeyed scent, mingling with the green smell of paddy water. By midmorning, the blossoms will close again — this brief flowering belongs only to those who rise early.

Dragonflies patrol the lotus ponds in territorial circuits, their wings catching the morning light like flecks of mica. Tree frogs call from the shade of broad lotus leaves, their voices carrying far across the water. The summer heat has settled in fully now, and cicadas begin their chorus earlier each day, the sound building in waves through the humid afternoons.

At Shinobazu Pond in Ueno and lotus-viewing sites across Japan, early risers gather for kanren — lotus appreciation. The Japanese have long associated the lotus with spiritual purity, its blossoms rising immaculate from murky water. Buddhist temples hold special dawn viewings, and some estates serve lotus tea, brewed by pouring water through the dew-filled leaves.

蓮開く音なき音に目覚めけり

lotus opening — / I wake to the soundless sound / of its unfolding



鴻雁来

Wild geese arrive from the north

K■gan kitaru

In the predawn stillness, a distant honking drifts down from clouds still holding the night's chill. The geese arrive in wavering V-formations, their wings catching the first rose light as they descend toward reed-fringed wetlands. The air carries that particular clarity of mid-autumn — sharp enough to taste, cool enough to quicken the breath.

Wild geese from Siberia begin their annual arrival at Japan's lakes and coastal marshlands, their calls echoing across water surfaces pearled with morning dew. Cosmos flowers stand in full bloom along riverbanks, their delicate pink petals trembling in winds that carry the faint sweetness of kinmokusei beginning to fade. The rice harvest continues in earnest, leaving stubbled fields where flocks will soon forage.

The arrival of the wild geese has been watched for centuries as confirmation that autumn has truly settled in. In classical poetry, the kari (wild goose) appears as a messenger between worlds — linking the living to departed loved ones, summer shores to winter skies. Farmers once timed certain late plantings by the geese's first calls, trusting the birds' ancient rhythms more than any calendar.

雁の声遠き湖面に波紋かな

wild goose calls — / across the distant lake / ripples spread



芹乃栄

Water parsley flourishes

Seri sunawachi sakau

EDITORIAL COPY PENDING

The winter letter is not in the source cache yet. This spread tests image scale, type hierarchy, margins, and the winter palette only.

No seasonal observations, food notes, cultural claims, or haiku have been invented for this proof.